

Light Logic

Consistent, believable lighting

Light logic means that every shadow and light in your drawing is consistent with a single, coherent light source. Inconsistent lighting is one of the most common ways a drawing feels 'off' even when the drawing is technically correct.

KEY CONCEPTS

One Light Source Rule

Unless you're deliberately working with multiple light sources (studio lighting, candlelight + window, etc.), establish ONE light source and make everything consistent with it. Decide: where is the light? How high is it? How far?

Light Families

Group your values into two families: the light family (highlight + midtone) and the shadow family (core shadow + reflected light + cast shadow). The lightest shadow should always be darker than the darkest light. This separation reads clearly at any distance.

Mapping Before Rendering

Before shading, do a simple black-and-white map: light side = white, shadow side = black. No gradients. This forces you to commit to the light logic before you get lost in rendering. If the map doesn't read, the rendering won't either.

Shadow Direction

Cast shadows always fall opposite to the light source direction. If light comes from upper left, shadows fall lower right. Check every cast shadow in your drawing — do they all point the same direction?

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw an arrangement of 3 objects with a single lamp. Before shading, make a B&W map.
 2. Copy a master drawing and check: is every shadow consistent with one light source?
 3. Draw the same object with light from 4 different directions. Map the shadows each time.
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FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Understanding Light

<https://youtu.be/V3WmrWUElJo>

■ Watts Atelier – Light Logic